

Sri Lanka



An ancient civilization ravaged by civil war as the Tamil population attempts to secede.

400s BCE Indo-Aryan migrants from northern India settle on the island. Emergence of the Sinhalese as the most powerful of the numerous clans.

200s BCE Tamils migrate to the island from India.

1017 CE Sri Lanka is conquered by the Chola Empire.

c.1070 Cholas expelled.

1200s Arab traders establish bases on the island.

1411 Cheng Ho, a Chinese admiral, captures the island's king and takes him to China.

1505 Portuguese fleet lands in Sri Lanka, then known as Ceylon.

1656–1796 Period of Dutch control.

Artistic sophistication

This elegant 8th-century gilded figure of the Buddhist goddess Tara is a superb example of Sri Lankan bronze casting.



1802 Ceylon becomes a British crown colony by Peace of Amiens, formalizing British control of areas occupied in 1796.

1815 British occupy Kandy, winning control over the whole island, and start bringing in Tamil laborers from southern India to work tea, coffee, and coconut plantations.

1833 English made the official language.

1931 Constitutional reforms are introduced with the assurance of self-government in the near future and universal suffrage.

1948 Island is granted full independence.

1949 Indian Tamil workers are stripped of suffrage and citizenship rights.

1956 Solomon Bandaranaike is elected prime minister. He makes Sinhala sole official language.

1959 Bandaranaike assassinated. He is succeeded by his widow, Sirimavo, the world's first woman prime minister.

1972 Name changed to Sri Lanka, and Buddhism promoted as main religion, antagonizing Hindu Tamils.

1975 Tamil Tigers formed amid mounting tension in Tamil north and east.

1977 Separatist Tamil United Liberation Front party wins all seats in Tamil areas.

1983 Tamil Tigers begin civil war.

1985 First attempts at peace talks between Tamil Tigers and government end in failure.

1987 Indo-Sri Lankan peace agreement leads to dispatch of Indian peacekeeping force to Tamil areas.

1990 Indian force leaves. Violence between army and Tamil Tigers escalates.

1993 President Premadasa killed by Tamil suicide bomber.

1994 Left-wing PA wins election; Chandrika Kumaratunga president.

1995–2001 War in north and east.

1999 Kumaratunga is wounded in assassination attempt. She is reelected.

2002 Ceasefire signed. Civilian flights to Jaffna in Tamil north resume and road links reopen. Tamil Tigers drop demand for a separate state.

2004 Renegade Tigers regain control of east. More than 30,000 killed by tsunami.

2006 Tigers begin a bombing campaign in breach of the 2002 ceasefire. Intense fighting with government forces. Peace talks resume in Geneva but break down.

2007 Government troops clear eastern coastal areas of rebels. Thousands of civilians flee the fighting. President Mahinda Rajapaksa's government finally wins a parliamentary majority after 25 opposition MPs defect to its side. Tigers launch first jet air strike.

2008 Sri Lankan government renounces the truce with the Tamil Tigers and launches a major offensive.

2009 Government forces capture Kilinochchi, Tamil Tiger administrative headquarters, and the remaining Tamil Tiger positions, ending the civil war. The Tamil Tiger leader Velupillai Prabhakaran is killed in the fighting.

2010 President Rajapaksa wins a new presidential term, but the result is rejected by his opponent General Fonseka.

Maldives



An island nation making a difficult transition to democracy after years of colonial rule.

1153 According to legend, the Maldivian king is converted to Islam by an itinerant Muslim holy man.

1558–73 The islands are occupied by the Portuguese, who are evicted by Bidu Muhammad Takurufana al Azam, a hero of Maldivian history.

1887 British protectorate over the islands formalizes British control.

1932 First democratic constitution: the sultanate becomes an elected position.

1965 Full independence from the UK.

1968 Sultanate abolished. Ibrahim Nasir elected first president of new republic.

1978 Maumoon Abd al-Gayoom becomes president on Nasir's retirement.

1980s Development of tourist industry fuels economic growth.

1988 Coup attempt involving Sri Lankan mercenaries is defeated.

1994 Nonparty legislative elections.

1998 New constitution; Gayoom is reelected for fifth five-year term.

2002 Government takes legal action against US for failing to endorse Kyoto Protocol on carbon emissions.

2003 Amnesty International accuses Maldives of torture and political repression. Antigovernment riots occur in Male. Gayoom is reelected for sixth term.

2004 Gayoom promises to allow formation of political parties and to limit the presidential term of office. Prodemocracy demonstration turns

violent and a state of emergency is declared. Scores are killed and several islands devastated by tsunami.

2005 Unanimous vote in parliament to allow multi-party politics.

2006 Gayoom pardons senior opposition leader Jennifer Latheef, imprisoned on terrorism charges.

2008 Gayoom defeated by Mohammed Nasheed in presidential elections.

Bangladesh



A young, flood-prone country that surrounds the confluence of the Ganges and Jamuna rivers.

1905 Muslims persuade British rulers to partition the state of Bengal and create a Muslim-dominated East Bengal.

1906 Muslim League is established in Dhaka.

1912 Partition of 1905 is reversed.

1947 British withdraw from India. Partition establishes a largely Muslim state of East (present-day Bangladesh) and West Pakistan, separated by 1,000 miles (1,600 km) of Indian, and largely Hindu, territory.

1949 Awami League founded to campaign for autonomy from West Pakistan.

1968 General Yahya Khan heads government in Islamabad.

1970 Elections give Awami League, under Sheikh Mujib Rahman, a clear majority in East Pakistan. Rioting and guerrilla warfare follow Yahya Khan's refusal to convene the assembly. The year ends with the worst recorded storms in Bangladesh's history—between 200,000 and 500,000 are killed.

1971 Civil war starts as Sheikh Mujib Rahman and Awami League declare unilateral independence. Sheikh Mujib is arrested and taken to West Pakistan. East Pakistan army mutinies. Ten million Bangladeshis flee to India. Pakistani troops are defeated in 12 days by Mukhti Bahini—the Bengal Liberation Army.

1972 Sheikh Mujib returns and is elected prime minister. Country changes name to Bangladesh. Nationalization of key industries, including jute and textile. Bangladesh achieves international recognition and joins Commonwealth. Pakistan withdraws in protest.

1974 Severe floods damage rice crop.

1975 Sheikh Mujib is assassinated in a military coup. General Zia ur-Rahman takes power and institutes a single-party state. Martial law is imposed.

1976 Banning of trade union federations.

DECISIVE MOMENT

CHILDREN PROTEST, 2003

On October 6, 2003, an unprecedented demonstration broke out among school children in Valachchenai in the east of Sri Lanka. Despite fears of violent reprisals, they sat in the roads and blocked traffic in protest at the abduction of 23 of their classmates by the Tamil Tigers. The abduction took place just hours after the Tigers had agreed a program with the children's charity Unicef to return child soldiers to their families. The demonstration drew world attention to the plight of children, such as this one (right), forced to fight as soldiers by the Tiger rebels.

